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Regeneration

Earthworms have their most important organ in the first 20 segments. If earthworm gets cut after the 20th segment, the anterior half can regenerate, while the posterior half shall disintegrate after some time.

The female reproductive system consists of a pair of **ovaries** lying in the 13th segment. Each ovary has finger like projections which contain ova in linear series. Ovarian funnels are present beneath the ovaries which continue into the **oviducts**. They join together and open on the ventral side as a single median female genital pore in the 14th segment. **Spermathecae** or **seminal receptacles** are three pairs lying in segments 7th, 8th and 9th, opening to the exterior on the ventral side between 6th & 7th, 7th & 8th and 8th & 9th segments. They receive spermatozoa from the partner and store during copulation.

A mutual exchange of sperms occurs between two worms during mating. One worm has to find another worm and they mate juxtaposing opposite gonadal openings, exchanging the sperms. Mature egg cells in the nutritive fluid are deposited in the cocoons produced by the gland cells of the clitellum which also collects the partner's sperms from the spermthecae. Fertilization and development occurs within the cocoons, which are deposited in the soil. After about 2 – 3 weeks, each cocoon produces baby earthworms. Development is direct and no larva is formed during development.

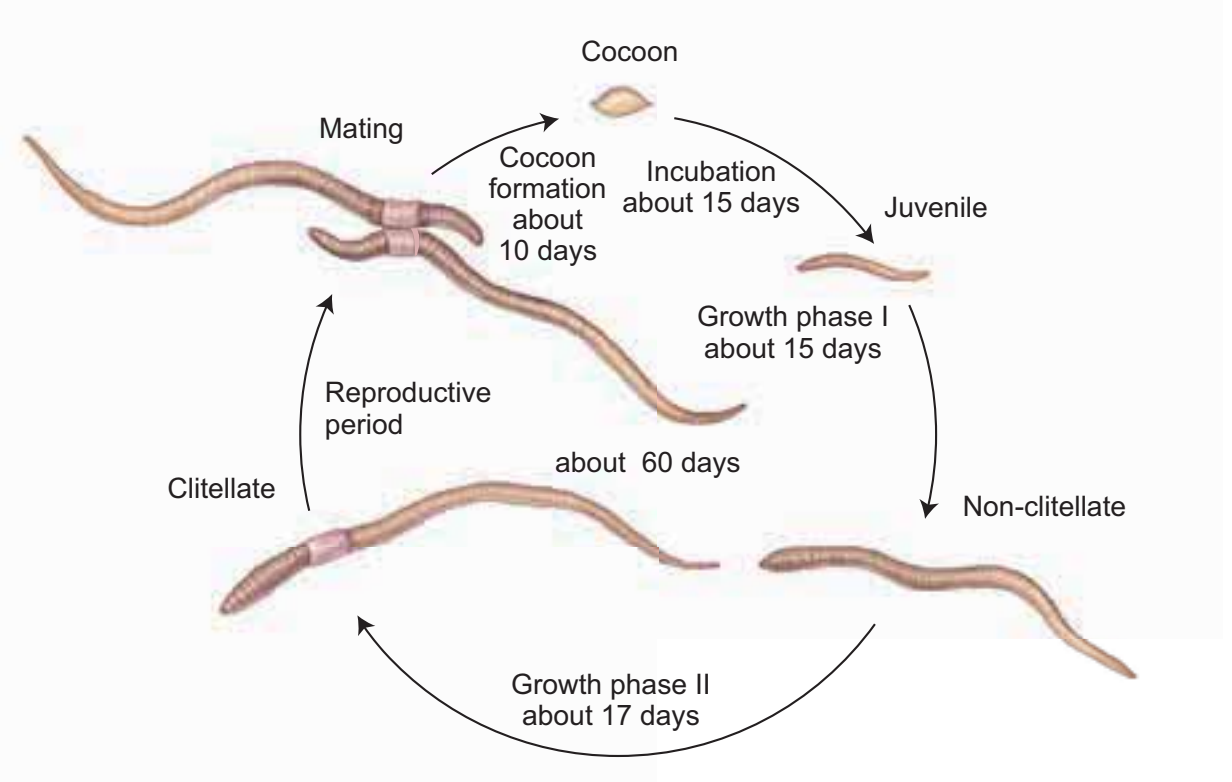


Figure 4.7 Life cycle of *Lampito mauritii*